ISSUE 9

GALLIONS grapevine

July 2002

GALLIONS HOUSING ASSOCIATION



Tony Cotter, Bryan Richards and Andrea Kilvington from Gallions, pictured outside their offices with Inspector John Salisbury Jones and The Police Motorcycle Project

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Our Community Safety Strategy

A major element of our Community Safety Strategy is developing projects that implement natural surveillance within your community that best identify and co-ordinate local needs with our existing and future resources. One such scheme is Neighbourhood Wardens.

Neighbourhood Wardens

Our **Neighbourhood Wardens** scheme is now on target to commence in August. The project manager and the Wardens have been recruited and training and familiarisation with the community and local needs or problems will start during their first month. During this training the Wardens will meet community groups and key members of the local community to start understanding the needs of the community that they will serve.

Our Wardens come from different backgrounds with various complementary skills, which reflect the diversity and needs of our local population.

We recognise that the Wardens are not an absolute solution and therefore cannot solve all the problems we face locally but they will work hard to improve the environment we live in whilst discouraging anti-social behaviour and reducing crime.

The main objective of our Wardens is to complement the police as well as to provide employment and a wide range of training within our local area. This was achieved through our pre-recruitment training, which was aimed at familiarising local people with the Wardens project and providing potential candidates

continues on

Meet our new editor

Hi my name is Bryan Richards and I am the new editor of the Gallions Grapevine. I am also responsible for Public Relations and Communications for Gallions Housing Association and my aim is to increase our publicity and awareness together with the profile of Thamesmead.



If you have any constructive comments or suggestions on the Grapevine or any of the services that we provide, please contact me via the feedback section on the back page of this issue. Thank you

See **back page** for your list of contacts



Team Gallions

ENVIRONMENTAL SERVICES

On 9th May we officially launched our new in-house environmental services called **Team Gallions**. The deputy Mayor of Greenwich and colleagues from the London Borough of Greenwich and Bexley together with the police attended the launch. *Left to right: Tony Hughes, LB Bexley; John Fahy and Peter Dalley, LB Greenwich; Harbans Buttar, LB Bexley; Sue Chalkley and Tony Cotter, Gallions HA; Gurmel Singh Kandola, LB Greenwich and Mike Frizoni, LB Bexley.*

This is in line with our strategy to work closely with primary schools to raise awareness amongst younger children about issues surrounding environmental nuisance and anti-social behaviour. We believe that we should challenge negative attitudes before they develop and become too difficult for us to address.

Enviro Rangers

We would like to welcome the children and teachers of the four schools that form our **Environment Rangers**. St Margaret Clitheroe, Hawsmoor, Northwood and Abbey all received Environment Rangers packs that give the children the necessary tools and contacts for reporting graffiti, abandoned vehicles, dog mess, damaged public lights and anything else that is bad for our environment. The school with the most reported environment issues will receive a grant of £500 from us.





with the necessary skills to apply for not only the **Neighbourhood Wardens** positions but also other employment vacancies.

Anyone interested in becoming involved in helping us with the ongoing development of this project or have suggestions for us should contact their housing co-ordinator.

Policing and Local Authority Partnerships

In line with our Community Safety Strategy, we have developed a series of strategic partnership links with the police and both Greenwich and Bexley Councils to implement various projects, which address particular local problems.



Two officers who have recently completed their training have started preliminary patrol

Police on Bikes

Our motorcycle project, which is featured on the front page, was jointly funded by Gallions and the Government's Single Regeneration Budget. This will be commencing officially in July. The specially trained officers will be patrolling the surrounding areas to ultimately deter motorcycle nuisance as well as enhance Police and Warden patrols. Two officers who have recently completed their training have started preliminary patrols, which have already provided a deterrent effect.

May the Police Force Be With Us

We currently have a **Community Disorder Police** task force working in the area and people particularly around the Tavy Bridge area have reported a welcome increase in police patrolling the surrounding areas. They will be working locally for a trial period with a view to making a more concentrated commitment in the coming months under the London Borough of Bexley's Community Safety Action Zone Strategy.

Environment Crime Co-ordinator

We have recently submitted an application for funding from the Bridge House Estates Trust Golden Jubilee Grants fund for an environment-crime education co-ordinator.

This project will involve the enviro co-ordinator working closely with our primary schools to deliver training relating to environmental crime and anti-social behaviour prevention. This will build on the successful **Environmental Rangers** initiative, featured on page 2, introduced at the **Team Gallions** launch on 9th May.

Gallions Helps Drug Raid

The drugs raid on 8th April is an example of our successful partnership development with the local police, local authorities and the community. Police officers acted upon information made possible from our vigilance and the efforts of our staff where upon entry of the property in Byron Close, over 250 full-grown cannabis plants were found.

To be consistent with our Community Safety Strategy we will seek to rigorously enforce breaches of tenancy where criminal activity, anti-social behaviour and nuisance are involved. Congratulations to all those concerned with this drug raid.

Zero Tolerance

A resident in Maran Way was reported to have thrown a sofa and two armchairs from the 3rd floor landing to the ground below. Following an investigation by our Housing staff it was concluded that the allegation was true. Eviction proceedings have been started because this dangerous action broke the tenancy agreement. Any reports of similar incidents will be dealt with promptly by our staff.

Gallions' Final Thought

In order to make Thamesmead a great place to live we are maximising our resources and strategic partnerships. However we cannot do it alone and need your help and involvement.

To help us to reinforce the efforts of our staff towards the appropriate resources, please let us or the Police know what is going on in your area. You can contact us on Freephone 0800 838481 or either Bexley Police on 0208 301 1212, or Greenwich Police on 0208 855 1212.

No matter how frustrating it is when you feel that you are not getting the response you deserve, please continue to report crime, anti-social behaviour and nuisance.

Remember to always get a 'Computer Aided Dispatch' (CAD) number from the Police to confirm that your report has been properly recorded.



Gallions Ecopark, currently nearing completion

Coming soon!

Ecopark

In November, we will be officially opening our environmentally friendly housing scheme called Gallions Ecopark, which is based at Gallions Reach Urban Village. Ecopark is a development of 39 environmentally sustainable and affordable homes and 8 flats for rent and sale, which seeks to demonstrate how we can contribute to environmental policies and procedures.

A distinct feature of our Ecopark is a Visitor Centre and Naked House, which will provide a unique opportunity for visitors of all ages and backgrounds to examine the design and detail as well as identify broader environmental issues. Based on the Dutch Green Financing Model the scheme seeks to promote awareness of the need to encourage prime innovative housing.

Ecopark Ecological Features

The principal aim of Ecopark's environmental sustainability strategy is to significantly reduce the impact of the use of energy, materials and water upon the environment. The scheme is primarily concerned with creating lower running costs, less demand on fossil fuels and reduced harmful emissions balanced with an enhanced quality of life for residents.

The houses and flats within our Ecopark will incorporate different technologies to reduce the consumption of energy in different combinations. Unique features include:

- **Sunrooms**
- **Solar Collectors for pre-heating domestic water**
- **Wind pressure controlled natural ventilation air supply**
- **Under floor heating**
- **Low temperature heating**
- **Individual condensing gas boilers**
- **Grey water recycling**
- **Low flush toilets**
- **Water saving taps**

For more information visit our website www.gallionsecopark.co.uk





TAVY BRIDGE Regeneration Project

UPDATE TAVY BRIDGE

The initial step in the regeneration scheme is to deal with residents' top priorities. The first preference is security so CCTV is being installed in the Tavy Bridge area. Anti-social behaviour and criminal activity around the Tavy Bridge will be recorded by a series of cameras. If you witness anything, please call the Police or us on 0800 838481 so that recorded images can be passed on to the Police. The installation of security cameras is in direct response to the issues raised by local residents through surveys that we conducted last summer as well as recent Focus Group meetings. The next step is to deliver environmental improvements and to consult with residents and local agencies on the vision for the new Tavy Bridge.

COMMUNITY RENEWAL

COMMUNITY CHEST

We will be introducing a Community Chest fund in the near future, which will offer grants to Gallions residents to fund community based projects. Applications can come from recognised Tenants' and Residents' Associations or from local residents who have a project they would like to run for the benefit of their local community.

If you are interested in getting involved in this project please contact Kaye Sene 020 8320 3462 or via email ksene@gallionsha.co.uk

SKY TV CON!

There is a man, working in the Disraeli Close area so far, wearing a sky digital t-shirt and he is operating illegally by offering a reduced installation fee of £30.00 for Sky TV if you pay on the day, then not returning to install it. The police are aware and are looking for him, if you know who he is or were recently contacted by him, call the Police or our customer response centre on 0800 838481.

Please remember that you must make sure you have obtained planning permission from us first before any installation.

OOPS! On the recent Tavy Bridge Newsletter, the contact number for PC Rob Evans at Belvedere Police Station should read:

020 8284 5528 or
020 8284 5529

Sorry for any inconvenience caused. *Kaye Sene, Community Renewal Assistant*





Youth Music Project

We are launching an exciting project with Trust Thamesmead to deliver music training for young people in Thamesmead.

Young people aged between 16-25 will have the opportunity to work with the latest music production software in a supported environment. They will also be able to gain a London Open College Network qualification and get assistance to enter further training or employment opportunities. Young people aged 13-16 will also be able to attend special sessions to experiment with the music software.

If anyone is interested in attending the music sessions, please contact Kaye Sene on 020 8320 3462.

The project will be managed by In-Volve and will be based in the old Millennium music studios at Gallions' offices. It is due to start in August/September 2002.



BMX skateboard park is on its way!

We are in the process of developing a BMX skateboard park. We would like to hear your thoughts and ideas on the type of park and the equipment needed. If you are interested in getting involved in this project please contact Kaye Sene 020 8320 3462 or via email ksene@gallionsha.co.uk.

Paint away!

We are looking at the possibility of an organised graffiti wall for the use of the local community. The scheme will allow local artists to display their work in a designated and safe environment. The consultation process with young people from the local Youth Awareness Programme (YAP) is underway.

If you are interested in this project or have any ideas you would like to share with us please contact Kaye Sene on 020 8320 3462 or via email ksene@gallionsha.co.uk.

IMAGES: MONICA LAU, RYAN MCVAY/GEDDSTOCK/GETTY IMAGES



The Great Jubilee Knees Up

Residents across Abbey Wood and Thamesmead went Jubilee crazy in June as part of the celebrations to mark the Queen's 50 year reign. The theme, adopted and planned by ourselves, Trust Thamesmead and Tilfen Land, was a runaway success.

The festival started with a colourful and vibrant carnival procession with many costumes and big displays developed by primary schools from Thamesmead and Abbey Wood. 50 workshops were held at 14 primary schools as kids were given an artistic license to draw pictures, make facemasks and costumes.

Five decades of music featuring Hot Chocolate and Gerry and the Pacemakers together with an abundance of talent from local schools, such as Kate Williams, a 16-year-old A level student from Abbey Wood, also contributed to the show's success. A host of other bands performed as well with TV warm-up man Jeff Stevenson compering the show.

We would like to thank and congratulate everyone who took part in the festival and hope you had a thoroughly enjoyable day.







IMAGES: MONICA LAU, RYAN MCVAY, GEOSTOCK/GETTY IMAGES

Rubbish Dumping

We are continuing to experience problems with a small number of residents inappropriately disposing of household refuse, unwanted furniture etc. throughout parts of Thamesmead.

As you can appreciate the cost and labour involved in removing this rubbish is extensive and obviously could be put to better use in other ways. Dumping rubbish poses a potential safety hazard and also a health risk by attracting vermin to the area.

We are trying various initiatives to prevent this behaviour, such as using lorries for bulk rubbish removal at various points during the holidays. Also, if we are able to identify persons who dump rubbish or leave bags of rubbish in the wrong place, we pass on the removal cost to the culprits.

Please ensure that all refuse is disposed of in the correct manner. Depending on the area and the type of property, this will either be done by placing it in small bags in the refuse chute or putting it out for the local authority disposal operatives on the day of collection. Any larger bulk items such as furniture should be taken to your local civic amenity site as detailed below:-

Bexley Residents
FMCS BTS
Thames Road,
Crayford

Greenwich Residents.
Nathan Way,
Thamesmead,
Kent, DA1 5QJ

If you are unable to visit the amenity site, the local authority will collect the item(s) but there will be a charge for this if you live in the Bexley Borough.

The telephone numbers for the collection service are:-

Bexley Residents
0208 303 7777
Ext 5562
(special Collection)

Greenwich Residents
0298 311 5229



Please help us to keep your environment clean, healthy and safe.

REVENUE RECOVERY TEAM

We Are Here to Help

As your registered social landlord our aim is to provide affordable housing and to help keep you in your homes. We can only do this if your rent is paid.

If you are experiencing difficulties paying your rent it is important you talk to us. The rent and arrears you have will still need to be paid but we can help you with our expert advice and agree an affordable arrangement to help you repay your debt by installments. Court hearings can prove costly and can affect your credit rating.

We are here to help you and the earlier we can deal with your arrears the less likely you are to end up in court and risk eviction.

If you are in arrears with your rent, call our Customer Response Centre now on 0800 838481.

Don't ignore your arrears, they will not go away!

Q&A: Benefits

"I made a claim for housing benefit over 6 weeks ago. I filled in the form and then took it to the Council where they copied all my documents. Since then I have not heard anything from the Council. I have now received a letter from Gallions to tell me that I am in arrears with my rent. I have been told that I could be taken to court unless I pay rent. I am a single parent and I get income support, what shall I do?"

Advice from your Welfare Benefits Officer

You must contact the Council straight away to make sure that you have given all the evidence that the Council have asked for. The form that you completed should have indicated what was needed, and the person at the Council who copied your documents should have advised you if something was missing.

If they have asked for something that you can not provide, then you must tell the Council why you cannot provide it and contact the Welfare Benefits Officer at Gallions as soon as you can.

You are always liable to pay rent even though you have claimed housing benefit. The Council may owe you money, but that will not necessarily mean that you would not be taken to court because of the rent that you owe to Gallions.

If you have given all the evidence required, or there is a good reason why you cannot provide it, then you should tell the Council that you want a payment on account. This is an interim payment until a proper decision can be made on your claim. If you are refused, you should contact the Welfare Benefits Officer at Gallions.

PHOTO: ISTOCKPHOTO



THUMBS UP from the Housing Corporation!

In January 2002 The Housing Corporation, our regulatory body, carried out an inspection of Gallions Housing Association to determine whether we are improving our services for the future.

The inspectors spoke to our tenants, staff and board of management as well as local authorities, contractors and other organisations we work closely with.

5 of the 21 key findings of the report are:

- **We have introduced major structural management changes allowing us to be flexible and our staff provide a helpful and courteous service, which is easily accessible and satisfactory to our residents.**
- **Our new Customer Service Centre is attractive and welcoming through its design and the free postal address and phone number are advertised and well used.**
- **Our properties are well maintained and we actively seek and work with partners to tackle anti-social behaviour.**
- **We should monitor ethnicity of residents who make complaints or report harassment/domestic violence (which is now in place).**
- **We should ensure that the next Customer Survey measures the impact of recent changes to customer service (due May 2003).**

If you would like to add any constructive comments about the findings of this report, or would like to be sent a copy of the report, please see the feedback section on the back of this issue for contact details.
Thank you.



Board members Ronke Adeagbo and Ken Sealey officially opening our Customer Response Centre in May

NEW CUSTOMER RESPONSE TEAM LEADER

As part of our commitment to provide and develop the best possible service to our tenants, in May we recruited a new Response Centre Team Leader Doreen Lawrence.

Gallions would like to welcome Doreen who has joined us from Capita Housing Benefit, based at Erith Town Hall and has worked within the Customer Service sector for the past 25 years therefore bringing a vast amount of experience and knowledge to our service standards.

Customer Response Centre Continues to Improve

Since the official opening of the Customer Response Centre on 3rd May, the number of calls we have received has significantly increased.

The total number of calls recorded so far estimates at 14,906 for April and May with over 5,000 calls already recorded up to the third week in June.

As can be seen by the number of calls we are receiving, we are providing an invaluable service to our residents. Recognising this Doreen said, "we are dedicated in continuing to improve our service standards as we are now looking at new technology in the form of 'state of the art' computer systems and additional staff to help improve our service".

Our commitment to our tenants is paramount and if you have any constructive suggestions or comments on how we can improve our customer response centre service, call Doreen Lawrence on our freephone number 0800 838481

New Tenants' and Residents' Association in Thamesmead

Congratulations to the residents of Buckwheat, Teeswater and Shire Courts, who successfully launched the BTS Courts Tenants and Residents Association (TRA) on 11th June. The launch was followed by a Cheese & Wine Evening, organised by the Committee. We would like to thank the committee who have worked hard to get the group up and running. The next meeting of TRA will be on Wednesday 14th August 2002, 7pm Teeswater Atrium.

GALLIONS BREAKS THE LANGUAGE BARRIER

We have provided a genuine equal opportunity within our community through the recent introduction of the Language Line service. This means that when you speak to one of our revenue officers or customers service advisors we can arrange for a language line interpreter to liaise with both parties and translate for any of our non-English speaking tenants.

Therefore we have removed the language barrier guaranteeing that you will be interpreted confidentially and accurately in over 100 different languages.

Board meeting

Main decisions taken by the Board at the Meeting of 17th June 2002

● BME Strategy

The board approved the BME strategy for Thamesmead, 'Living Together', which was produced by the Black and Minority Ethnic Working Group, chaired by Tokky Ademoyero. The strategy follows the structure and headings recommended by the NHF Code of Practice but the detail is very specific to Gallions and Thamesmead. The Working Group firmly believes that the strategy will bring about improvements through practical action-based tasks and the Board will monitor performance against this strategy on a six monthly basis.

● Board Meetings

Gallions Housing Association's Board of Management meets on a regular basis. The meetings are open to all residents. In order to accommodate any residents who wish to attend, you would need to contact our company secretary Averyl Richards through our customer response centre number on 0800 838481 or alternatively email her on arichards@gallionsha.co.uk. You will need to arrange this prior to any meetings to make the necessary arrangements.

The dates of the next meetings are:

● 19th September 2002 ● 12th December 2002
● 20th March 2003

Residents' Learning Bridge

The Residents' Learning Bridge is a new group of residents and staff from eleven housing associations in South London which is working to provide residents with opportunities for training, learning and networking. We expect to be able to bring you more in the future, but we have teamed up with Bromley College to offer two free courses. Please contact Jill McNiven, whose details are below, if you are interested.

Working in your community

Would you like to take a more active part in your community? Interested in attending a short course?

By attending 2 hours a week for three weeks you will cover:

- Understanding your community.
- Where do you fit in?
- Being a team player

Committee skills

Would you like to gain the confidence to organise and run meetings? Interested in attending a short course?

By attending 2 hours a week for three weeks you will cover:

- Taking minutes
- Chairing meetings
- Budgets

For more details about the Residents' Learning Bridge, please contact: **Jill McNiven**
Gallions Housing Association
Tel: 0208 320 3417
jmcniven@gallionsha.co.uk

Feedback

Win 4 tickets to experience our Ecopark's unique Visitor Centre

We welcome your suggestions and constructive comments on how we can improve our services and make your environment and home a better place to live in.
For a chance to win 4 tickets to experience our Ecopark's unique Visitor Centre and Naked House, simply send your comments to:-
Feedback, Gallions Grapevine, Bryan Richards, Gallions Housing Association, Harrow Manor Way, London SE2 9XH.

Don't forget to add your name, address and telephone number for contact details or alternatively email me on brichards@gallionsha.co.uk
The closing date will be Friday September 27th.

Contact us

ਜੇ ਅੰਗਰੇਜ਼ੀ ਤੁਹਾਡੀ ਪਹਿਲੀ ਭਾਸ਼ਾ ਨਹੀਂ, ਅਤੇ ਤੁਸੀਂ ਇਸ ਦਸਤਾਵੇਜ਼ ਦਾ ਤਰਜਮਾ ਚਾਹੁੰਦੇ ਹੋ, ਤਾਂ ਕਿਰਪਾ ਕਰਕੇ ਆਪਣੀ ਚੁਣੀ ਹੋਈ ਭਾਸ਼ਾ ਦੇ ਨਾਂ ਦੇ ਨੇੜੇ ਢਾਲੇ ਅਗੇ ਵਿਚ ਸਹੀ ਦਾ ਨਿਸ਼ਾਨ ਲਾ ਕੇ, ਅਤੇ ਚੁੱਸੀ ਹੋਈ ਥਾਂ 'ਤੇ ਆਪਣਾ ਨਾ ਅਤੇ ਪਤਾ ਲਿਖ ਕੇ ਇਹ ਫ਼ਾਰਮ ਕਿਸੇ ਲਿਫ਼ਾਫ਼ੇ ਵਿਚ ਪਾ ਕੇ ਹੇਠ ਲਿਖੇ ਪਤੇ 'ਤੇ ਭੇਜ ਦਿਓ।

如果英語不是您的母語，您希望將該文件翻譯出來的話，請在您選擇的語言旁邊打勾，請在所示之處填上您的姓名和地址，併用信封將本表格寄到下列地址。

Nếu Anh ngữ không phải là ngôn ngữ chính, Quý vị muốn dịch tài liệu này, xin vui lòng đánh dấu vào ô kế bên ngôn ngữ Quý vị chọn, ghi tên và địa chỉ vào nơi chỉ dẫn và gởi mẫu vào phòng bì theo địa chỉ dưới đây.

PUNJABI ☐ **CHINESE** ☐ **VIETNAMESE** ☐ *(please tick one)*

Name: .....

Address: .....

.....

Return to: Bryan Richards (Translation Requests), Gallions Housing Association, Harrow Manor Way, London SE2 9XH

Gallions Housing Association
Harrow Manor Way
London SE2 9XH

Customer Response Centre
Freephone
0800 83 84 81

This freephone number is now taking all calls to Gallions via the Customer Response Centre, this also includes switchboard calls.

The old switchboard number will be withdrawn in the coming months.